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Virat Kohli pulled the plug on an illustrious Test career, announcing his exit from the longest format as India embarks on a fresh World Test Championship cycle.

Dwindling returns in recent years and a tame show in Australia — perhaps his favourite hunting ground away from home — at the turn of the year proved the last straw.

Since 2021, Kohli averaged less than 32 across 63 innings and produced only 11 scores of 50 or more, highlighting a sharp decline from his lofty standards. A dip in output at a time when his contemporaries, Joe Root and Steve Smith, for instance, were thriving under a second wind, only compounded Kohli's lack of form.

But an insipid end barely dulls the sheen off his almost 14-year run in Tests.

Kohli burst onto the fold during the 2014 tour of Australia when he commanded Mitchell Johnson, England's tormentor-in-chief in the Ashes just one summer earlier. Kohli racked up 692 runs in eight innings during that series, including four tons.

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BATTER EXTRAORDINAIRE

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was up to the task against the hallowed pace trio of Mitchell Starc, Josh Hazlewood and Pat Cummins, averaging more than 50 against Starc and Hazlewood. He averaged over 50 across all Tests against these two bowlers, before it plummeted during his final outings against them.

For Kohli, no challenge was too stiff. James Anderson and Stuart Broad found him out in the corridor of uncertainty during India's tour of England in 2014. But Kohli emphatically banished the horrors of that wretched tour on his next visit in 2018. He scored 593 runs in that series and averaged close to 60.

Anderson and Broad's late movement under swing-friendly conditions, once thought to be his 'kryptonite', was rendered ineffective. On that tour, Anderson failed to dismiss him in eight innings and Broad managed to do so

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